

DauidsTown Insurance

Protecting homes across the county since 1962

HomeShield

Home Insurance — Policy Wording

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This booklet sets out the terms of your HomeShield home insurance. Read it together with your **schedule**, which shows the sections that apply to you, your sums insured, your excesses and any special conditions. Where the schedule and this wording differ, the schedule takes priority.

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This edition applies to policies inceptioned or renewed on or after the effective date shown above. If your policy was inceptioned or renewed before that date, an earlier edition of the wording applies to it. Always check the edition reference printed on your schedule.

Summary of changes in this version

- Storm wind-speed definition aligned to 47 knots (54 mph), Beaufort force 9.
- Garden and outbuildings default limit increased to £1,500.
- Police notification window for theft shortened to 24 hours.
- New cover added for escape of oil or fuel from a fixed heating installation (Section 3).
- New general exclusion for communicable disease (Section 9).

Contents

Section 1 — About your policy and definitions

Section 2 — Making a claim

Section 3 — Escape of water and escape of fuel

Section 4 — Storm, flood and weather

Section 5 — Fire, lightning and explosion

Section 6 — Theft and malicious damage

Section 7 — Accidental damage (optional)

Section 8 — Reserved

Section 9 — General exclusions

Section 10 — Excess summary

*Words shown in **bold** in this booklet have the specific meaning given to them in Section 1.*

Section 1 — About your policy and definitions

Your HomeShield policy is a contract between you and DavidsTown Insurance. In return for your premium, we provide the cover described in the sections shown as included on your schedule, subject to the terms, limits, excesses and exclusions in this booklet. This wording should always be read alongside your schedule.

Definitions

Home. The private house or flat at the address shown on your schedule, including its domestic outbuildings, fixtures and fittings, and the land within its boundaries.

Buildings. The structure of the **home**, together with garages, outbuildings, walls, gates, fences, drives, paths and swimming pools within the boundaries of the **home**.

Contents. Household goods, personal belongings and valuables that belong to you or a member of your household, or for which you are legally responsible, and that are in the **home**.

Excess. The amount you must pay towards each claim. The amount that applies is shown on your schedule and summarised in Section 10.

Period of insurance. The length of time your cover runs, as shown on your schedule, and any period for which we accept your renewal premium.

Storm. A period of violent weather with wind speeds of at least 47 knots (54 mph), or torrential rainfall, hail or snow of similar severity.

Flood. The escape of water from a natural watercourse, lake or the sea, or an accumulation of rainwater that is unable to drain away normally, entering the **home**.

Unoccupied. A **home** that has not been lived in by you or a person authorised by you for more than 60 consecutive days.

Section 2 — Making a claim

If you need to claim, contact our claims line as soon as you reasonably can. The specific steps for each type of loss are set out at the end of the relevant section. In every case you must:

- take reasonable steps to prevent further loss or damage;
- tell us about the loss or damage as soon as reasonably possible;
- keep any damaged property so we can inspect it, unless we tell you otherwise;
- give us the information and help we reasonably need to assess the claim;
- not admit liability or agree to pay any claim without our written consent.

Fraud

If any claim is found to be fraudulent, exaggerated, or supported by false information or documents, we will not pay it and we may cancel your policy from the date of the fraudulent act. See Section 9.3.

Section 3 — Escape of water and escape of fuel

3.1 What is covered

We will pay for damage to your **buildings** and **contents** caused by water escaping suddenly and accidentally from:

- a fixed water tank, apparatus or pipe, including washing machine and dishwasher supply hoses;
- a fixed heating system, including burst or frozen pipes;
- a domestic appliance with a plumbed water connection.

This includes the reasonable cost of tracing the source of the escape and making good the damage caused by that tracing work, up to £5,000 unless a higher limit is shown on your schedule.

3.2 Frozen pipes

Damage caused by frozen pipes is covered under this section, provided you have taken reasonable precautions to prevent freezing, such as keeping the heating on in cold weather or draining down the system when the **home** is left unoccupied for more than 30 consecutive days. A claim may be reduced or refused if the **home** was left unheated and unoccupied during freezing conditions without the water system being drained.

3.3 Gradual damage is excluded

We do not cover damage that happens gradually, including:

- seepage or percolation of water over a period of time;
- condensation;
- a leak that has been running for more than 14 days before it was discovered;
- damage arising from wear, tear, corrosion or a lack of maintenance.

If our loss adjusters determine that a leak was gradual rather than sudden, the claim falls under the general exclusions in Section 9 and is not payable under this section.

3.4 Excess

The standard excess for an escape of water claim is £250. Where the escape originates from a shower tray, wet room or similar fitted wet area, an increased excess of £500 applies, reflecting the higher frequency of claims from this source.

3.5 Waiting period

There is no waiting period for escape of water cover; it applies from the policy start date, unless the policy was taken out to replace cover that lapsed more than 30 days earlier, in which case a 14-day waiting period applies before a new escape of water claim can be made.

3.6 Escape of oil or fuel

We will pay for damage to your **buildings** and **contents** caused by oil or fuel escaping suddenly and accidentally from a fixed domestic heating installation or its supply pipe, up to £2,000. The clean-up of contaminated ground within the boundaries of the **home** is included within this limit. Gradual seepage of oil or fuel is excluded on the same basis as gradual water damage.

3.7 Claims process

Report an escape of water as soon as it is discovered. Turn off the water supply at the stopcock if it is safe to do so, and take photographs of the damage before any repair work begins. Keep any damaged items until an adjuster has inspected them or confirmed by phone that this is not necessary.

Section 4 — Storm, flood and weather

4.1 What is covered

We will pay for damage to your **home**, garden and outbuildings caused directly by **storm**, **flood**, or lightning strike (including a direct strike to the **buildings** or a strike causing a power surge that damages wired-in electrical installations).

Where wind lifts or displaces roof coverings and rain then enters through the opening, we assess the claim as a **storm** claim rather than an escape of water claim. What matters is the peril that created the opening, not the water that subsequently came through it.

4.2 Outbuildings, fences and gardens

Sheds, garages, greenhouses and fences are covered up to £1,500 in total per claim, unless a higher garden and outbuildings limit is shown on your schedule. Trees, plants and hedges are not covered against **storm** damage, except for the reasonable cost of removing a fallen tree that is blocking access to your **home**.

4.3 What is not covered

- damage that happens because the **buildings** were already in a state of disrepair before the **storm** (for example, a roof that needed re-felting);
- damage to fences, gates and hedges caused by wind alone, unless a tree or other object was blown into them;
- frost damage, which is treated as gradual and falls under the general exclusions;
- loss of external paint, render or cladding finish where the underlying structure is undamaged.

4.4 Excess

The standard excess for storm and flood claims is £250. Where the **home** is in a flood-risk postcode identified on your schedule, a flood excess of £1,000 applies specifically to flood claims; the standard £250 excess continues to apply to storm and lightning claims at that address.

4.5 Multiple claims from one weather event

If a single **storm** or **flood** event affecting your area causes more than one claim under this policy within a 72-hour window, they are treated as one claim for the purpose of the excess, so only one excess is deducted in total.

4.6 Claims process

Take reasonable steps to prevent further damage, such as fitting temporary roof covers, but do not carry out permanent repairs until an adjuster has inspected the damage or confirmed by phone that inspection is not required. Emergency repair costs up to £500 are reimbursed without prior authorisation when the alternative would be to leave the **home** exposed to further damage or intrusion.

Section 5 — Fire, lightning and explosion

5.1 What is covered

We will pay for damage to your **home** and **contents** caused by fire (including scorching and smoke damage, whether or not the fire spread beyond its original source), explosion (including a domestic gas explosion), and lightning strike causing direct fire damage. A lightning strike causing only a power surge, with no fire, is covered under Section 4. Damage caused by smoke drifting from a fire that was not on your property is also covered under this section.

5.2 Electrical fires and faulty appliances

Fire damage caused by a faulty domestic appliance, including tumble dryers, washing machines and electrical wiring, is covered. We may seek to recover our costs from the manufacturer or retailer if the appliance was found to have a manufacturing defect and was still within the manufacturer's stated lifespan; this does not affect your claim being paid.

5.3 Cooking fires

Fires starting in a kitchen, including chip-pan and cooking-oil fires, are covered in the same way as any other fire. There is no reduction in cover for a fire that started through an accident in the course of ordinary cooking.

5.4 What is not covered

- damage caused by a fire deliberately started by you or a person living with you (see Section 9.3);
- scorching or heat damage that occurs without an actual fire, such as a mark left by a hot pan on a worktop;
- the appliance's own mechanical fault, which is not separately warranted or repaired under this policy, although damage to the appliance caused by the fire is covered under **contents**.

5.5 Excess

The standard excess for fire, lightning and explosion claims is £250. There is no separate higher excess for kitchen or cooking-related fires.

5.6 Claims process

Call the fire service for any fire beyond a small, contained and immediately extinguished flame. Do not re-enter a fire-damaged **home** until it has been confirmed safe. Retain damaged items, including the appliance believed to be the source if known, for inspection.

Section 6 — Theft and malicious damage

6.1 What is covered

We will pay for loss or damage caused by theft or attempted theft involving forcible and violent entry to or exit from your **home**, and by malicious damage, meaning damage deliberately caused by another person, including vandalism and graffiti.

6.2 Evidence of forcible entry

A claim for theft requires visible evidence of forcible and violent entry, such as a broken window, forced lock or damaged door frame. Theft through an unlocked or open door or window, with no sign of force, is not covered. This is the single most common reason theft claims are declined, so photograph any damage to the point of entry before it is repaired.

6.3 Outbuildings and garden items

Theft from a shed, garage or other outbuilding is covered up to £1,500 in total, or the garden and outbuildings limit shown on your schedule if higher. Pedal cycles are covered up to £500 unless a higher specified-item limit is shown on your schedule; a bicycle stolen from an unlocked shed with no forced entry is not covered under either this clause or clause 6.2.

6.4 Theft while the home is unoccupied

If your **home** is left unoccupied for more than 60 consecutive days, theft cover is suspended unless you told us in advance and we agreed to continue cover, which may be subject to additional conditions such as periodic inspection.

6.5 What is not covered

- loss of money or valuables left in a vehicle, even if the vehicle was forcibly entered;
- theft or malicious damage by a tenant, lodger or paying guest of yours;
- loss discovered during a routine inventory but with no evidence of when or how it occurred.

6.6 Excess

The standard excess for theft and malicious damage claims is £250. Where a claim follows a break-in with no evidence of forced entry that we later agree to pay under a case-by-case exception, an increased excess of £500 applies.

6.7 Claims process

Report any theft to the police within 24 hours of discovery and obtain a crime reference number; a claim submitted without one will be delayed while we request it. Do not disturb the scene at the point of entry until you have photographed it.

Section 7 — Accidental damage (optional)

7.1 What is covered

Accidental damage cover is an optional add-on, shown as "Accidental Damage: Yes" on your schedule. Where it applies, we pay for sudden and unintended damage that is not otherwise covered or excluded elsewhere in this policy, such as spilling paint or liquid on a carpet, putting a foot through a ceiling while using loft storage, a DIY accident that damages the structure, or a child or pet accidentally breaking an item inside the **home**.

If "Accidental Damage: No" is shown on your schedule, none of the events in this section are covered, however the damage occurred. Check Sections 3 to 6 first, since some accidental events (a burst pipe, a kitchen fire) are covered there without this add-on.

7.2 Ceilings and falling objects

Damage to a ceiling from an object falling from above, or a ceiling collapsing under its own weight due to a fault unrelated to water ingress, is covered under this section where accidental damage cover is in place. Where a ceiling collapse was caused by escaping water, the claim is assessed under Section 3 instead, and the escape of water excess and conditions apply.

7.3 Garden accidents

Accidental damage to garden items such as greenhouses, garden furniture and ornaments caused by an identifiable one-off accident (for example, a football breaking a greenhouse pane) is covered up to the garden and outbuildings limit on your schedule. Gradual wear, such as a fence panel rotting, is not accidental damage.

7.4 What is not covered

- damage caused deliberately, even by a household member (see Section 9.3);
- mechanical or electrical breakdown of an appliance with no identifiable accidental trigger;
- damage that is also excluded under another section, such as gradual water seepage, which remains excluded even with accidental damage cover in place;
- cosmetic damage that does not affect the function of the item, such as a small scratch on furniture.

7.5 Excess

The excess for accidental damage claims is £150, lower than the £250 that applies to the perils in Sections 3 to 6, reflecting the typically smaller size of accidental damage claims.

Section 8 — Reserved

This section number is reserved and is not in use in this edition of the wording. Home emergency cover is not offered under this edition.

Section 9 — General exclusions

These exclusions apply across every section of this policy, in addition to the specific exclusions listed within each section.

9.1 Wear, tear and maintenance

We do not cover loss or damage arising from wear and tear, gradual deterioration, corrosion, rot, rust, damp, mould, or any other process that develops over time rather than happening suddenly. This applies regardless of which section would otherwise cover the type of damage.

9.2 Lack of maintenance

We do not cover damage that a reasonable programme of home maintenance would have prevented, including a known leak left unrepaired, guttering that was visibly blocked or damaged before a storm, or a roof known to need repair before the damage occurred.

9.3 Deliberate or fraudulent acts

We do not cover any loss caused deliberately by you or a person living with you, and we may void the policy entirely if a claim is found to be fraudulent or exaggerated, or if you knowingly provide false information in support of a claim.

9.4 Unoccupied property

Where a claim arises while the **home** has been unoccupied for more than 60 consecutive days, cover is reduced to fire, lightning and explosion only, unless you told us in advance under the terms described in Section 6.4. Escape of water, storm, theft and accidental damage claims are not paid during an unnotified period of extended vacancy.

9.5 War, terrorism and nuclear risks

Loss or damage caused directly or indirectly by war, terrorism, nuclear reaction or radioactive contamination is excluded from every section of this policy without exception.

9.6 Communicable disease

We do not cover any loss, cost or expense caused by, contributed to by, or arising from any communicable disease, or the fear or threat of a communicable disease, including any associated cleaning, disinfection or loss of use of the **home**. This exclusion applies even where another cause contributed to the loss at the same time or in any sequence.

9.7 How exclusions interact with cover sections

An exclusion in this section overrides a coverage grant in Sections 3 to 7. For example, escape of water is covered under Section 3, but a leak running for more than 14 days before discovery is gradual damage and is therefore excluded under 9.1, regardless of the wording in 3.3. When a claim could be described under more than one section, the general exclusions are checked against the actual cause of loss, not the section a claimant assumes applies.

9.8 Claim limits across sections

Unless increased limits are shown on your schedule, the total we will pay across all sections combined in any one period of insurance is £500,000 for **buildings** and £75,000 for **contents**. Sub-limits within individual sections, such as the £1,500 outbuildings limit in Sections 4 and 6, count towards these totals rather than sitting outside them.

Section 10 — Excess summary

The table below summarises the standard excesses under this edition. The amount that actually applies to your policy is the amount shown on your schedule, which may differ if you chose a voluntary excess.

Type of claim	Excess
Escape of water (standard)	£250
Escape of water (shower tray / wet room)	£500
Storm and flood (standard)	£250
Flood (flood-risk postcode on schedule)	£1,000
Fire, lightning and explosion	£250
Theft and malicious damage	£250
Accidental damage	£150

End of policy wording. DavidsTown Insurance · DTI-HOME-PW-2023-v1.0 · Version 1.0 · Effective 1 January 2023.